him to sign a deal with Applause Entertainment to secure adaptation rights to six of his most celebrated works. "I got fed up with people stealing my films and my ideas, and printing my books and selling them in the streets at a third of the price! I'm not complaining though, because I like being read," he adds with a smile.

He may be writing his last novel, but he is far from putting the pen down. "I hope to keep writing short stories, plays and film scripts among other things," he says.

Archer hopes to keep writing short stories, plays and film scripts among other things

And although he has entertained the idea of writing a memoir, Archer believes he might never write one. But, if he were to, what would he call it? He thinks for a second, before responding—"Proust said, 'we all end up doing the thing we're second best at.' I'd have to find a title that described that, because I should have captained the England cricket team. I should have been Prime Minister. I should have won a gold medal at the Olympics, but I ended up being a storyteller! And again, I am not complaining, because telling a story is like being a ballet dancer or an opera singer. It's a God-given gift." ■

—Deepali Dhingra



WELCOME ALL *DDLF's curtain raiser at Sahitya Akademi, New Delhi*

FESTIVAL ▼

Voices in the Valley

The latest edition of the DEHRADUN LITERATURE FESTIVAL from Nov. 14-16 will gather leading writers, artists and thinkers for three vibrant days of ideas and performances

The 2025 Dehradun Literature Festival (DDLF) will be held at Doon International School from November 14-16. This will be the seventh edition of the festival, which began in 2017. This year, the DDLF will host a wide range of practitioners across disciplines—writers, translators, publishers, actors, filmmakers, musicians and so on. The invited speakers include Justice D.Y. Chandrachud, Shobhaa De, Abhay K., Arundhati Subramanian, Sam Dalrymple, Sean Doyle, Imtiaz Ali and Divya Prakash Dubey.

"When we began in 2017, I wanted to set up a literature festival in Dehradun simply because I knew that this is such an important educational centre, and that we would receive a terrific response from students and teachers [at Doon International School]," shares DDLF founder Samraant Virmani. "During the first year, we had only 10 events and maybe 1,000 visitors, and now we are sitting on over 50 events and 50,000-plus visitors. What has remained constant is that we have never charged for entry. We want to keep it that way."

THIS WILL BE THE SEVENTH EDITION OF THE FESTIVAL, WHICH NOW HOSTS OVER 50 EVENTS FOR 50,000-PLUS VISITORS

During the festival, a pair of awards named after Shivani and Ruskin Bond (two of the best-known writers from the hills of Uttarakhand) honour resilience, empowerment and literary achievements. In addition to a full lineup of literary conversations, there are also panels and events focusing on cinema and the performing arts. For example, a panel on inclusivity in cinema will reunite several people involved in the recent Aamir Khan film *Sitaare Zameen Par,* which depicted a sports team of differently abled youngsters.

Justice Chandrachud will headline two separate conversations involving Indian democracy, including one with schoolchildren. There are panel discussions around folk music traditions, not to mention musical performances in the evening.

"There's so much going on every day at the festival, so many ideas and concepts being discussed," says Virmani, "that sometimes visitors can get overwhelmed." The musical performances, he hopes, will act as a kind of mental reset. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha